

LOYALTY BONUS

The new PCC chief will have to keep an eye on foes within as he readies the party to wrest power from the BJP later this year



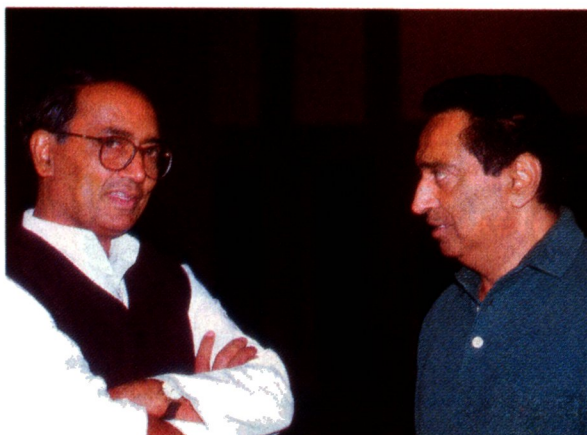
Take away the flamboyance and there is little that would separate Suresh Pachauri, the newly-appointed Madhya Pradesh Congress Committee president from Pramod Mahajan, the late BJP leader. Like Mahajan, Pachauri harnesses computers for political analysis and he has facts and figures at his fingertips, ready for reel-off when called for.

But if snazzy gizmos were all it took to win polls, geeks would have made it as lawmakers. Pachauri would need much more than smart political analysis to meet his biggest challenge: lead the party to victory at the assembly elections due this December. A fractious and dispirited state party unit, a bunch of old pros waiting for even a minor slip from him and a ruling BJP that rode to brute majority the last time round in 2003—the odds are stacked up against the diminutive Pachauri, the first Brahmin to have made it as the head of the state party unit in over two decades. And despite polite denials, he is the front-runner for the chief ministerial post if the party wins. And if he does be-

BACKROOM BOY: Pachauri is not a mass leader, but 10 Janpath's choice come the chief minister, it will have more to do with Pachauri's unwavering loyalty towards 10 Janpath than anything to do with his administrative acumen.

Pachauri loyalists cite the resurgent BSP and its tried and tested formula in Uttar Pradesh of wooing the upper castes as the reason behind his para-dropping into the state unit with barely nine months to go before the polls. But that's an argument fraught with dangerous consequences in a state where Brahmins, the cogs in BSP's

OPTING OUT: Singh and Nath (right)



social engineering tool, number nowhere near as they do at 12 per cent in Uttar Pradesh. Pachauri's name had been doing the rounds for almost two years and it was always a matter of when he will be entrusted with the job.

But even before Pachauri begins to contemplate taking on the BJP, he has to deal with the fissures in his own party first. An assertive Jyotiraditya Scindia, who was being tipped as a possible candidate for the post of Pradesh Congress Committee (PCC) president, isn't likely to create trouble for Pachauri. But none of the other senior party leaders from the state—Union Commerce Minister Kamal Nath, former chief minister Digvijay Singh or Union HRD Minister Arjun Singh—was in favour of him taking over as PCC chief. When it became clear in January that PCC chief Subhash Yadav was on his way out, the combined Digvijay-Arjun camp tried to pitch in for the latter's son Ajeya Singh to be appointed as the next PCC president. Now, Ajeya has been made the chief of the poll campaign committee. Says Pachauri, "All the senior leaders including Arjun Singh, Kamal Nath, Digvijay Singh, Jyotiraditya Scindia and others have assured their cooperation in the mission to defeat BJP."

Pachauri, who is adept at Congress-style politics where back-room manipulations and back-stabbing are a norm, can count on steadfast support from the party high command. This, more than anything else, should ensure that he gets to pick the PCC office-bearers of his choice while balancing the various factions. But he will not be able to brush away taunts from the established order that he remains one of the few politicians to have risen to such heights without ever winning an election, though he has had four successive terms in the Rajya Sabha since 1984.

With his methodical ways and support from the high command, Pachauri would certainly pose bigger challenges for the Shivraj Singh Government in Madhya Pradesh than the Congress has done over the last four years. Whether he can lead the party to success remains the million-dollar question.

by Ambresh Mishra